

TUITION PROGRAMS

In accordance with Policy 7630, Loudoun County Public Schools (LCPS) recognizes the necessity for a well-trained, professional workforce. LCPS also recognizes that critical areas of need may arise within the division, which pertain to workforce training. The tuition assistance programs exist to build the capacity of schools and offices to function as learning communities to promote student achievement. The goal is to increase employee effectiveness within a current position and to assist employees in preparation for other positions within LCPS. The purpose of this regulation is to delineate the roles and responsibilities for implementing a tuition assistance program and a tuition reimbursement program for LCPS employees.

A. Definitions:

1. Tuition Assistance: A Tuition Assistance program is one in which the division determines the specific educational programs, services, or opportunities for which the division will provide financial assistance. The educational programs, services, or opportunities will be identified based upon the critical staffing and operational needs of the school division. In a Tuition Assistance program, the division will assist by paying all or most of the costs for employees accepted into one of the identified educational programs, services, or opportunities. The division will directly pay service providers for most tuition assistance programs in an effort to reduce the financial burden on the employees accepted into an assistance program. The primary goal of a tuition assistance program is to support employees in acquiring new skills and advancing their education to be eligible for critical need positions within the division and/or to support the successful operation of the school division.

2. Tuition Reimbursement: A Tuition Reimbursement program is one in which an employee may be reimbursed for a select amount for education-related expenses incurred by the employee. The eligibility criteria and both employer and employee expectations will be clearly defined by the LCPS department managing the tuition reimbursement program. Priority may be given to critical need cohort programs, educational programs, or other educational opportunities to meet critical areas of need within the division. The goal of a tuition reimbursement program is to support employees in acquiring new skills, advancing their education, and ultimately contributing more effectively to the division.

B. Tuition Assistance:

1. Eligibility: Eligibility for tuition assistance is determined based on several factors:

- a. The applicant must be an LCPS employee and in good standing;
- b. The employee must complete the required application process;
- c. The employee must maintain employment with LCPS for at least two years immediately following the approval of tuition assistance;
- d. The employee must successfully complete the program to which the tuition assistance applies; and
- e. The employee is only eligible for one tuition program per fiscal year.

2. LCPS' Roles and Responsibilities for Tuition Assistance: LCPS' Department of Human Resources and Talent Development (HRTD) oversees LCPS' offered tuition assistance program.

- a. HRTD determines the specific programs and purposes for utilizing budgeted tuition assistance funds based on the critical needs of the division.
- b. HRTD maintains procedures and guidelines on the application process, eligibility criteria, appropriate use of funding, and approval process.
- c. Tuition assistance should not exceed the amount approved in the HRTD tuition assistance budget.
- d. Tuition assistance requirements and processes will be clear, concise and consistently applied.
- e. Tuition assistance documents, if applicable, should be properly submitted.
- f. Properly submitted tuition assistance requests will be timely paid, if applicable.

3. LCPS Employees' Roles and Responsibilities for Tuition Assistance: Each LCPS employee seeking tuition assistance for an eligible program is responsible for the following:

- a. Reviewing and complying with the established guidelines;
- b. Submitting requests for assistance within the published deadlines, including all appropriate paperwork required by HRTD;
- c. Submitting applications to program providers within published deadlines and being accepted into an eligible tuition assistance program; and
- d. Ensuring the accuracy of information submitted for tuition assistance.

C. Tuition Reimbursement

1. Eligibility: Eligibility for tuition reimbursement is determined based on several factors:

- a. The applicant is a full-time employee;
- b. Employees must have completed their first contracted day of employment;
- c. The employee must apply and receive acceptance to the institution of higher education and begin the course/program;
- d. The employee must maintain employment with LCPS for at least two years immediately following the completion of the course/program;
- e. The employee must complete the course with a grade of "B" or higher for a VDOE licensure requirement or a passing status for a trade certification course;
- f. Departmental scholarship agreements provide specificity regarding the application process, program requirements and level of tuition reimbursement for critical need cohorts; and

- g. The employee is only eligible for one tuition program per fiscal year.

2. LCPS' Roles and Responsibilities for Tuition Reimbursement: Each respective LCPS department is responsible for implementing and overseeing the operations of the tuition reimbursement program(s) established within their specific LCPS department.

- a. Each interested LCPS department should maintain procedures on how critical need cohort programs or educational programs are established, advertised, and maintained.
- b. Each LCPS department is responsible for notifying HRTD when a cohort or educational program is beginning or ending.
- c. Tuition reimbursement should not exceed the amount approved in the operating budget for the specific department.
- d. Tuition reimbursement guidelines established for each department should include descriptions of reimbursable tuition expenses, reimbursement procedures and a database of tuition reimbursement applications and transactions.
- e. Tuition reimbursement requirements and processes will be clear, concise and consistently applied by departments.
- f. Priority may be given to employees participating in a cohort program or educational program to meet critical areas of need.
- g. Tuition reimbursement documents should be properly submitted.
- h. Properly submitted tuition reimbursement requests will be timely paid.

3. LCPS employees' Roles and Responsibilities for Tuition Reimbursement:
Each LCPS employee seeking reimbursement for eligible professional development tuition is responsible for the following:

- a. Reviewing and complying with the departmental guidelines regarding established critical need cohort programs or educational programs;
- b. Submitting requests for reimbursement within the published deadlines, including all appropriate paperwork for those expenses that have been paid by the employee; and
- c. Ensuring/certifying the accuracy of information submitted for tuition reimbursement.

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